A market can record every win and still lose sight of the alternatives.

The same song finishes first in one market and fortieth in another. An early contract gives one firm the references its rival needs. A thousand AI agents produce answers—but who gets to test a different approach?

Martin Erlic introduces the comparison budget: a way to examine the opportunities a reinforced market preserves for learning about alternatives. Following experiments, economic history and the emerging AI economy, Shadow Futures asks what success can tell us about contribution—and what it can leave unresolved.

From work and capital ownership to competition and taxation, the book asks how institutions can preserve worthwhile discovery while keeping the benefits of scale.

SHADOW FUTURES

MARTIN ERLIC

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## How Markets Choose Winners—and Lose Sight of the Alternatives.



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